Whose concern is it? - complete text version

You have finished a first call about a proposed cloud-based analytics platform for Klatch Mercantile, a fictional importer of artisanal food and drink. Match each concern to the given buying-team responsibility it most directly addresses, so you can prepare a useful response. In a real call, several people may share a concern; a question alone does not prove who has approval authority. Work through four short stages. Match five notes to the given case responsibilities, compare two reasons for the rollout concern, match four more notes without the reminder card, then write a useful customer relationship management (CRM) note. Use the stated case responsibilities rather than assuming a concern belongs exclusively to a permanent buyer type. The company and the people are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 10 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. Read each note and match it to the given responsibility it most directly addresses, then read the feedback for each option and compare it with your choice. For the rollout note, select the two responsibilities explicitly described. If you chose differently, note why the feedback disagrees and try the note again. Work through the stages in order, as in the interactive version. After two unsuccessful tries on a note, read its correct answer and the reasoning.

Role reminders

These role labels and responsibilities are assigned for this fictional purchase. Match what each note explicitly asks the team to assess. The labels are not proof that other people cannot share the same concern.

Sofia Alvarez, Champion

Head of Product Development. Wants tools that help Klatch Mercantile stand out in a competitive retail market and open up new possibilities for growth.

David Okoro, Decision-maker

Chief Financial Officer. In this fictional purchase, David has responsibility for approving the investment. He weighs budget impact, long-term value and financial sustainability, including indirect costs such as retraining.

Mei Tan, User

Sales Analyst. Will use the platform every day. Cares about usability, training and whether the platform simplifies her workload.

Markus Vogel, Blocker

Information technology security manager. Safeguards customer and supplier data. Puts compliance with security standards, fit with existing systems and avoiding disruption to operations first.

Stage 1 of 4: Tag the concerns

For each note, choose the given case responsibility it most directly addresses. Use the reminder card if it helps.

Note 1 of 5

“This could help us bring new services to market faster than our competitors.” Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns bringing new services to market and improving the product offer; the case gives that responsibility to Sofia.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns bringing new services to market and improving the product offer. David’s given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns bringing new services to market and improving the product offer. Mei’s given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns bringing new services to market and improving the product offer. Markus’s given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: Sofia Alvarez, the Champion. Record in the CRM as: Competitive advantage through new services.

Note 2 of 5

“If we switch systems, what will it cost us to retrain the team?” Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the financial cost of retraining as part of the investment. Sofia’s given card focuses on product development and growth.

- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns reviewing the financial cost of retraining as part of the investment; the case gives that responsibility to David.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the financial cost of retraining as part of the investment. Mei's given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the financial cost of retraining as part of the investment. Markus's given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: David Okoro, the Decision-maker. Record in the CRM as: The cost of retraining staff.

Note 3 of 5

"Will this help me get my reports done faster, without a lot of extra training?" Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns doing daily reporting with usable tools and manageable learning effort. Sofia's given card focuses on product development and growth.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns doing daily reporting with usable tools and manageable learning effort. David's given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.
- Mei Tan, the User - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns doing daily reporting with usable tools and manageable learning effort; the case gives that responsibility to Mei.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns doing daily reporting with usable tools and manageable learning effort. Markus's given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: Mei Tan, the User. Record in the CRM as: Faster reporting with little extra training.

Note 4 of 5

"Does it meet our data protection rules, and will it work safely with the systems we already run?" Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking data protection and safe integration with existing systems. Sofia's given card focuses on product development and growth.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking data protection and safe integration with existing systems. David's given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.

- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking data protection and safe integration with existing systems. Mei’s given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns checking data protection and safe integration with existing systems; the case gives that responsibility to Markus.

Answer: Markus Vogel, the Blocker. Record in the CRM as: Data protection and safe integration.

Note 5 of 5

“We need to assess the financial losses from interrupted trading and the security risks where the new platform connects to our existing systems.” Select the TWO given case responsibilities explicitly described in this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: This person may also care about rollout disruption. The note asks for two specific responsibilities, rather than everyone who could be affected. Compare each part of the note with the responsibilities in the role reminders.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Correct. Feedback: Yes. The note explicitly asks for review of financial losses from interrupted trading, which matches David’s assigned financial responsibility.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: This person may also care about rollout disruption. The note asks for two specific responsibilities, rather than everyone who could be affected. Compare each part of the note with the responsibilities in the role reminders.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Correct. Feedback: Yes. The note explicitly asks for review of security risks at system connections, which matches Markus’s assigned security and integration responsibility.

Answer: David Okoro, the Decision-maker and Markus Vogel, the Blocker. Record in the CRM as: Rollout disruption: financial effects and secure integration.

Stage 2 of 4: Same concern, different reasons

The same rollout issue can matter to people for different reasons. Use the responsibilities given in this fictional purchase to choose the reason behind each person's concern.

Why would David raise this concern?

- A disruption can mean financial losses and lower productivity while the rollout is under way. - Correct. Feedback: That fits. David’s assigned task is to review financial effects, so interrupted trading matters through lost income and productivity.

- A disruption would make the platform harder for people to learn. - Not the best fit. Feedback: This option focuses on how people learn the platform. Compare that focus with the responsibility given to this person in the case.
- A disruption could slow the launch of new services. - Not the best fit. Feedback: This option focuses on the timing of new products and services. Check whether that is the task assigned to this person for this purchase.

Why would Markus raise this concern?

- He wants operations to stay stable and the platform to connect to existing systems smoothly and with little risk. - Correct. Feedback: That fits. Markus's assigned task is to assess security and integration risk, so stable, safe connections are the reason given for his review.
- He wants to be sure the rollout stays within budget. - Not the best fit. Feedback: This option focuses on keeping within budget. Compare that focus with the responsibility given to this person in the case.
- He wants every user to find the platform easy from the first day. - Not the best fit. Feedback: This option focuses on ease of learning. Re-read the case responsibility and consider which concern it asks this person to assess.

One rollout issue can need several responses. Record the particular reason and the evidence behind it, rather than treating a role label as proof of everything a person cares about.

Stage 3 of 4: Tag four more without the card

Match four more notes to the given case responsibilities. The reminder card is closed; open it whenever you need it.

Note 1 of 4

"How quickly will people be able to get started on it?" Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns getting people started with the platform and making daily use manageable. Sofia's given card focuses on product development and growth.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns getting people started with the platform and making daily use manageable. David's given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.
- Mei Tan, the User - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns getting people started with the platform and making daily use manageable; the case gives that responsibility to Mei.

- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns getting people started with the platform and making daily use manageable. Markus’s given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: Mei Tan, the User. Record in the CRM as: Easy to get started.

Note 2 of 4

“Which retail data protection regulations does it comply with?” Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking the data-protection requirements for this proposed system. Sofia’s given card focuses on product development and growth.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking the data-protection requirements for this proposed system. David’s given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns checking the data-protection requirements for this proposed system. Mei’s given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns checking the data-protection requirements for this proposed system; the case gives that responsibility to Markus.

Answer: Markus Vogel, the Blocker. Record in the CRM as: Compliance with retail data protection regulations.

Note 3 of 4

“Could this open up products or markets we can’t reach today?” Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns exploring new products and markets; the case gives that responsibility to Sofia.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns exploring new products and markets. David’s given card focuses on investment approval and financial review.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns exploring new products and markets. Mei’s given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns exploring new products and markets. Markus’s given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: Sofia Alvarez, the Champion. Record in the CRM as: New products and markets.

Note 4 of 4

“Will this still be worth what we pay for it in a few years’ time?” Choose the given case responsibility most directly addressed by this note.

- Sofia Alvarez, the Champion - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the investment’s longer-term financial value. Sofia’s given card focuses on product development and growth.
- David Okoro, the Decision-maker - Correct. Feedback: That fits. The note concerns reviewing the investment’s longer-term financial value; the case gives that responsibility to David.
- Mei Tan, the User - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the investment’s longer-term financial value. Mei’s given card focuses on daily reporting, usability and training effort.
- Markus Vogel, the Blocker - Not the best fit. Feedback: The note concerns reviewing the investment’s longer-term financial value. Markus’s given card focuses on security and safe system integration.

Answer: David Okoro, the Decision-maker. Record in the CRM as: Long-term value for the money.

Stage 4 of 4: Record it in the CRM

Here is the concern map you have built. Choose one person to speak to first and write the entry you would add to their Notes column. Build your concern map from the notes you tagged. Under each person, list the concerns you tagged to their role. Note 5 belongs under both David Okoro and Markus Vogel. Then choose one person to speak to first.

Sofia Alvarez, Champion

- Competitive advantage through new services
- New products and markets

David Okoro, Decision-maker

- The cost of retraining staff
- Rollout disruption: financial effects and secure integration
- Long-term value for the money

Mei Tan, User

- Faster reporting with little extra training
- Easy to get started

Markus Vogel, Blocker

- Data protection and safe integration
- Rollout disruption: financial effects and secure integration
- Compliance with retail data protection regulations

A useful entry names the concern, says why this person raises it, and says what you will cover when you next speak to them. It should help a colleague who has never met this person to respond well. Write your entry for the Notes column. In the interactive version, Save my notes downloads your concern map and entry as a text file. An empty entry prompts: Write a short entry before saving. You matched the concerns to the responsibilities given in this fictional case. In a real purchase, record what each person actually says, confirm their role and note what still needs checking.